

India's opportunity will come if we want to plug into the reordering of supply chains. To tap this, we have to do bilateral and multi-sectoral trade agreements

–Arun K. Singh, *Former Ambassador of India to the United States*

The best way for us to get to Aatmanirbhar Bharat is to have an open economy with minimum barriers, for it means you realise your competitiveness

–Anup Wadhawan, *Ex-Commerce Secretary*

More than reciprocal tariffs, look at sectoral tariffs, which is Trump's route to bring back industrialisation to America. Whether he succeeds or not...we are in for a wild ride

–Ashok Malik *Partner, The Asia Group*

CHOPPY TRADE WATERS

With the sword of reciprocal tariffs hanging over its head, India lost no time in trying to seal a trade deal with the United States that aims to increase bilateral trade from $200 billion (Rs 17.4 lakh crore) at present to $500 billion (Rs 43.6 lakh crore) by the turn of the decade. But neither that deal nor India's decision to lower tariffs on some US imports like Harley-Davidson bikes or bourbon whiskey is likely to ward off the planned reciprocal tariffs. So what then are India's options? "The last time Donald Trump was in office, he was the least prepared president because nobody expected him to win. This time, he's probably the most prepared president," Ashok Malik, partner, The Asia Group, said at the India Today Conclave. Trump has spent four years preparing his agenda, and tariffs are an important part it, Malik added.

Arun K. Singh, former ambassador of India to the US, said that whatever happens, America wants to be No. 1. "As long as a technology competition exists with China, the US will find India a very, very valuable partner. US companies have realised that to maintain their edge, they need a partnership with India," he said. Ex-Union commerce secretary Anup Wadhawan was of the view that the best way to get to self-reliance was to have an open economy with minimum barriers. "Aatmanirbhar Bharat means you realise your competitiveness. So, you make it easy for your businessmen to invest and operate and, at the same time, make it easy for them to access inputs and technology from across the world," he said. So, Aatmanirbhar Bharat and reduced barriers at the border go together, he concluded. ■

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